American Poetry

By Ras Baraka

INTRODUCTION

Give me your tired, your hungry, your poor, your oppressed, your weary…these words appear on the Statue of Liberty welcoming those who migrate across the ocean to America. Immigrants have heard the cries promising freedom, and a better life for centuries now. Hundreds of thousands of people from around the world, have answered the call. Foreign lands and nations regard America as a proud country. However, an inspection of the social situations found in America today uncovers disparities in the educational system, poverty, high rates of crime and incarceration, and lack of access to quality health care, as well as racism and racial segregation. In American Poetry, Ras Baraka requests . . . no demands that the truth which exists for many Americans be told. American Poety by Ras Baraka.

Are there any american poets in here?

I wanna hear an american poem

Something America

A South Carolina slave shout a Alabama back woods

church call and

Response

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I wanna hear an american poem

an american poem

about sharecroppers

on the side of the road of families in cardboard boxes

not about kings

or majestic lands

or how beautifully ugly can be

I wanna hear something american

something about ghettoes

of Italians

of Germans

of Jews

of Black folk

about projects and lead poison

poverty and children in jail

I wanna hear a poem about picket lines

a Joe Hill legend struggle for an eight hour day

hey hey you hey you yeah you

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Where is all the american poetry
about Harlem number runners
and barbershop conversations
about colored faces on colored tv's
I wanna hear an American poem as American as a South
Bronx burner brandished
on an abandoned building a breakbeat, backspin, a beat
box, a rap song in
Congo square
Niggers beating on buckets on Broad St.
as american as the Zulu Nation and Latin Kings
i wanna hear an American poem
about a dead girl on Chadwick avenue with a bullet in her
neck
from a colored cop doing his job
ordered by fascism and crack cocaine
you know something made in the usa

Something american an Afro-Cuban Nuyorican Latin
tinge beating Bomba y Plena

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sprawling out of wide open tenement windows in the
middle of winter on
the verge of East Harlem or North Newark
Poems
of brown colonies
of Albizu being tortured for breating Taino blood
screaming African tongues
and dialoguing in Spanish
for being him PuertoRican self
and worst of all loving it
MY GOD
what happened to all the american poetry?
not poems about attics
or how your clothes fit
or fucking and stale slobber
nor your night before and morning afters
i don't want to hear about your statues and their
fantasies

there's no more American poetry
just death marches and stoic laughter

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niggers being funny
no more American poets
I wont boost your morale
play your songs
make you feel comfortable
build your ego
I just wanna hear an American poem
something native
like the trail of tears
wounded knee small pox in blankets
An american poem with American images
like *welcome back kotter white shadow* or *different strokes*
about white gods who guide helpless darkees on the road
to light

american
something that represents us
a colorful rainbow
a big bright fist
an uncorrected sentence

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improper English
as american as cointelpro
peekskill, new york Robeson singing out the back of a truck
Nina Simone playing at the BlueNote w/ Baldwin next to her on a stool
and Amina and Amiri Baraka in the audience
air filled with smoke cognac and Mississippi goddamn
capture that moment
right something abou that

an american masterpiece
an american poem
Something strictly american
like red summers, strange fruit, and the palmer raids

hey you you no you you and you yeah hey you
something american usa american usa american usa
american usa
as american as the kkk

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a poem about Emitt Till 'll do, the Tallahatchie river
church bombings and child murders
about Alabama red dirt and boycotts in Montgomery
about families migrating north with dignity and shotguns

I wanna hear a poem
a poem
about a beautiful blk boy
see him
a beautiful blk boy colored into the night
his eyes the stars
his hands our will
about a beautiful blk boy
in the middle of a project
playing checkers with glass and stone
who beats buckets as drums
and plays the horn in his sleep
I wanna hear a poem about a beautiful brown girl
an incredibly beautiful brown girl
with an aged mahogany smile
and flower petals for lips

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a beautiful brown girl
with a poem in her eyes
a poem in her eyes
and a gun in her hand
sitting in a puddle of tears
in clinton's women facility
in the garden state
in the land of the free
you know . . .
something american
something that represents me.

INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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